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TESTING TIMES Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan reviews NEET arrangements at the NTA office, Delhi, May 3

entirely above board. The Biwal family of Jamwa Ramgarh in Rajasthan, whose four children cleared NEET 2025 and were celebrated as a small-town success story, is now under CBI scrutiny. Investigators suspect Vikas Biwal bought the 2025 paper from the same network. He has since been arrested.

Radhakrishnan says the panel had already laid down guidelines for ensuring "the integrity and quality of the people and the process" involved in confidential operations—drawing questions from experts, assembling papers, selecting the final questions and verifying answers. NTA director-general Singh believes prevention—and the cure—lies in breaking the link between an expert and a specific examination. "The long-term solution is that you do not make papers for an exam on the eve of the exam," he says. "In fact, the experts who set the papers should not even know what exam they are making a paper for. It should be exam-agnostic." The way forward, he argues, is to build large question banks aligned with Class 12 proficiency and allow a randomised, AI-driven system to assemble papers. That would sharply reduce "the probability of an expert knowing that his question will figure in the paper".



"Every Kendriya Vidyalaya in each district could have 100 computer terminals. These can be used during major entrance exams and as computer learning centres for the rest of the year"

*— **Aditya Mittal,** Professor, IIT Delhi, and Radhakrishnan Committee member*

Despite its reformist ambition, the NTA still has no implementation timeline for the 33 recommendations the Radhakrishnan Committee listed under Phase 2: Long-term Perspectives. A committee member argues these should not take more than a year to roll out, especially since the government has already cleared the biggest of those shifts: moving NEET to CBT mode next year.

Fixing the Examiner

The deepest problem is the NTA itself and its organisational structure. "In the cabinet approval, NTA was envisaged as a premium testing agency which would use advanced technologies and conduct online tests," says Subrahmanyam. "It was supposed to be a very lean organisation, comprising highly accomplished persons. But a pen-and-paper exam of this sort needs some 10,000 people to run. Since the NTA does not have that, it depends on someone else, and that someone else cannot certify the integrity of the process."

Joshi, who headed the NTA between 2018 and 2023, says what is missing is plain expertise. "Conducting an exam is a technical job learnt through experience," he says. Someone who has actually run exams will implement an SOP differently from someone who has not. Cheating methods evolve every year, and "those trying to rig the system are experienced too". The fix, he says, is to put real examination experts in charge, and to stop expecting a young body to behave like an old one. "We should never compare NTA with CBSE and UPSC. NTA is eight years old, CBSE is from 1929, UPSC from 1926. Every agency takes time to learn."

That expertise has to be bought and respected. "If you want serious people to do the serious job of setting papers and handling confidential operations, compensate them well," says an expert committee member. Bansal points to the US Educational Testing Service, which runs the GRE and TOEFL and employs some 600 researchers. "NTA does not have too many psychometric or deep experts to set papers," he says. "These things have to be built, and that cannot be done in one year."

Some institutional scaffolding is beginning to appear, though. Acting on the Radhakrishnan Committee's recommendations, the government told Parliament that 16 new posts had been created in the NTA. So far, only seven have been filled, including four last month, after NEET had already been cancelled, taking the number of employees on deputation to 29. Last March, the government had told the Rajya Sabha that another 43 personnel were working at the NTA on contract.

Everything now rides on June 21, for the 2.28 million students taking the re-test and for the NTA. It will decide whether tighter protocols will salvage NEET or deepen the collapse of trust. Four families lost their children last month not just to a leaked paper, but to a system that was warned twice and did not take heed even once. ■